

Business and Technological Communication , Grade 12

Open

EBT40

This course emphasizes practical writing and communication skills that are needed in the world of business and technology. Students will analyse the characteristics of effective models of business and technical communications; gather information to write reports, business letters, memos, manuals, instructions, and brochures; and integrate graphics and text, using technology appropriately for formatting and special effects. They will also make a number of oral and visual presentations.

Prerequisite: English, Grade 11, University Preparation, College Preparation, or Workplace Preparation

Strands

The expectations in this course are organized into the following strands:

- A. Investigating Business and Technological Communications and Culture
- B. Producing Business and Technological Communications
- C. Metacognition

A. INVESTIGATING BUSINESS AND TECHNOLOGICAL COMMUNICATIONS AND CULTURE

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- 1. Understanding Business and Technological Communications and Culture:** demonstrate an understanding of a variety of types of communication, careers, and innovations associated with business and technological communications and related elements of business culture;
- 2. Analysing Business and Technological Communications:** identify key elements of a variety of business and technological communications, explain their function, and evaluate their effectiveness.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Understanding Business and Technological Communications and Culture

By the end of this course, students will:

Building Document Literacy

- 1.1** read and demonstrate understanding of a variety of current examples of business and technological communications (e.g., *complete a survey, a questionnaire, a work order form, or an online application for a postsecondary or apprenticeship program; make a judgement about whether or not to complete an optional part of a form; work with a peer to explain the main terms and conditions of an insurance policy*)

Teacher prompt: “Were the survey questions clear? What would you change if you had the chance to revise the survey?”

Identifying Purpose and Audience

- 1.2** identify the purpose and audience of a variety of business and technological communications (e.g., *determine whether a particular instructional manual is meant for experts or a general audience; determine whether a business letter or instructional video is designed to inform or to persuade; locate online information about e-mail etiquette for work-related communications, and explain why such etiquette is important; analyse a sequence of interview questions to determine the purpose of each; analyse an application form to determine the purpose of the different sections*)

Teacher prompts: “Who is the audience for this letter? In what way has the writer’s view of the audience influenced the content and style of the message?” “What are several different uses people might make of an instructional manual?”

Exploring Opportunities and Careers

- 1.3** research and demonstrate an understanding of a variety of opportunities and careers related to communications in business and technology and the skills needed to pursue them (e.g., *postsecondary programs related to business and technological communications; the role of a communications officer or information technology [IT] representative within a particular organization, such as the local school board*)

Teacher prompt: “What are some employment opportunities for writers in the field of business and technological communications? What type of skills and training would be required for each?”

Understanding the Impact of Technology

- 1.4** research and demonstrate an understanding of the ways in which communications technologies influence business practices (e.g., *the role of rich web communications systems that combine presentation, training, and online video-conferencing technology in supplementing or replacing face-to-face meetings that require travel; the impact of cellular technology on an individual’s work and private life; the impact*

of new communications technologies on corporate expectations of employees; the impact of new communications technologies on the ecological “footprints” of various businesses)

Teacher prompts: “How possible is it to have a paperless office?” “What are some examples of waste in the workplace?” “Has technology helped us to save time or has it made work more demanding than ever?” “Give an example of a communications technology that has increased efficiency in the workplace or home. Do you know of any examples that have decreased rather than increased efficiency? In what way?”

Understanding Business Culture and Issues

1.5 read and demonstrate an understanding of a variety of articles and interviews related to business and technology issues, innovations, individuals, organizations, perspectives, and practices (e.g., interviews with and articles by and about corporate leaders, small business owners, information technology professionals, entrepreneurs, and investment counsellors; articles on legal and ethical issues, such as communications patent infringement, or legislation related to Internet use)

Teacher prompts: “Why is it important to know about legal or ethical issues related to this business?” “What company or businessperson’s ‘profile’ did you find most interesting, or informative, or inspirational, and why?”

2. Analysing Business and Technological Communications

By the end of this course, students will:

Text Forms and Patterns

2.1 identify key elements of text forms and common organizational patterns used in business and technological communications, and explain how they help clarify the message and/or make information easier to find (e.g., the role of various elements found in different types of texts – such as tables of contents or online navigational guides with hyperlinks, introductions, the body of the text, appendices, and contact information; the function of headings in a report or of labels in a diagram; the use of sequential order in instructions; the role of words that identify locations or indicate spatial relationships in an instruction manual or a website; the use of side-bars for background information in a marketing proposal or company profile; the use of lists in reports and brochures; the order of items in a slide package for a business presentation)

Teacher prompts: “What is provided in each of these documents to help the reader locate information quickly?” “What elements do you see in common between these two different types of texts?” “How is this organized? Is this targeted to a reader within the company or a customer outside the company? How can you tell?”

Text Features

2.2 identify a variety of text features and explain how they are used to enhance the effectiveness of business and technological communications (e.g., the contribution of illustrations and graphics in a multimedia presentation for a general audience; the use of boldface and/or italics to highlight key terms and other important information in a brochure; the use of colour coding and/or pictograms and symbols to communicate basic information succinctly and help consumers navigate a brochure or manual)

Teacher prompts: “What features make this brochure helpful and appealing to the reader?” “What value is added by the illustrations in this text?”

Audio-Visual Features

2.3 identify audio-visual features used in business and technological communications and evaluate their contribution to the clarity and effectiveness of the text (e.g., explain how sound clips, animation, illustrations, and/or charts clarify information in a report to employees or shareholders; explain how presentation software helps emphasize key points in a sales pitch; determine whether the use of sound enhances a presentation)

Teacher prompts: “Did you find that the video clips distracted your attention from the speaker?” “Did the audio-visual aids provide essential support or were they pleasant but non-essential ‘add-ons’ to the main message?”

Oral Presentation Techniques

2.4 explain how volume, pace, pitch, tone of voice, eye contact, facial expression, posture, dress, movement, and gesture enhance or weaken the effectiveness of oral business communications (e.g., determine the suitability and effectiveness of the body language and tone of voice used in a motivational speech; identify speech patterns – such as falling or rising intonation – and determine whether or not their use is appropriate to the message and effective in engaging the interest of the audience)

Teacher prompts: “Did the speaker maintain good eye contact with the audience?” “Did the speaker’s gestures ‘punctuate’ the speech appropriately and effectively, or were they distracting or irritating?”

Language Choice

2.5 evaluate the language, including any specialized vocabulary, used in business and technological communications to determine whether it is appropriate to the topic, the purpose, and the audience’s level of knowledge about the subject (e.g., *determine whether the specialized language used in a memo really contributes to its accuracy and conciseness or is unnecessarily obscure and confusing; compare a text written in a plain-language style for a general audience to a text on the same topic written for experts, and comment on the benefits and drawbacks of each style; compare the language of the executive summary of a report to the language of the report itself and suggest reasons for the differences*)

Teacher prompts: “What terms in this text would need to be explained to a reader outside the industry?” “How would you describe the language of this letter?” “Why is the language used in forms often difficult to understand?”

B. PRODUCING BUSINESS AND TECHNOLOGICAL COMMUNICATIONS

OVERALL EXPECTATION

By the end of this course, students will:

1. **Producing Business and Technological Communications:** produce a variety of business and technological communications for different audiences and purposes, using appropriate forms and presentation features and techniques.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Producing Business and Technological Communications

By the end of this course, students will:

Purpose and Audience

- 1.1 explain how the identified purpose and audience influence their choices of content, organization, and style for the business and technological communications they produce (*e.g., a brochure to inform retailers about a company's products emphasizes the market appeal of the products; a memo to a manager summarizing consumer reports about a recommended purchase groups information under the headings "costs" and "benefits"; a list of frequently asked questions [FAQs] to prepare customer-relations trainees for the types of issues they may have to deal with incorporates case studies to help trainees understand different perspectives on the issues; a memo to meet the needs of different audiences – such as a manager, a technician, or the general public – adapts or explains technical language as appropriate to the level of expertise of the intended audience*)

Teacher prompts: "What will the audience need to know?" "What will the audience be expecting from the sales pitch?"

Text Features

- 1.2 use text features appropriate to the form and purpose to enhance the effectiveness of the business and technological communications they produce (*e.g., present information from text or a spreadsheet in chart or graph form; use colour to highlight main points in posted instructions; use sidebars to add visual interest and set off complementary or background information*)

Teacher prompts: "How can you make the report more visually interesting?" "How can you highlight important information effectively?"

Oral Presentation Techniques

- 1.3 use oral presentation techniques appropriate to the form, purpose, and audience to enhance the effectiveness of the oral business and technological communications they produce (*e.g., demonstrate awareness of appropriate dress and posture and use appropriate gestures, eye contact, and tone of voice in a mock interview; respond calmly and politely in the role of a company representative at a mock press conference about an environmental issue; smoothly coordinate speech, gestures, and the physical mechanics of technology when using projected images during a presentation; leave clear, straightforward, and succinct voice-mail messages*)

Teacher prompt: "Should you rehearse your presentation ahead of time to identify and avoid potential problems?"

Audio-Visual Aids

- 1.4 use a variety of appropriate audio-visual aids to enhance the effectiveness of the business and technological communications they produce (*e.g., use sound clips, animation, illustrations, and charts to enliven a slide presentation*)

Teacher prompt: "Do your audio-visual aids help to focus attention on your core message, or might they become a distraction?"

Quality Enhancement

1.5 revise, edit, and proofread drafts of business and technological communications they produce to achieve a professional standard of quality in content, organization, style, clarity, and design (*e.g., eliminate unnecessary details from a business letter; convert key ideas to point form in a report; add visual props to support an oral presentation; use a checklist to ensure that all necessary information and important details have been included in a brochure; use feedback from the teacher and peers to eliminate unnecessary jargon, improve word choice, and achieve a clear and appropriate style; compare drafts with appropriate models to identify areas for improvement in design and layout*)

Teacher prompts: “Is your information presented in a logical order?” “What changes might make your message clearer?” “What could you do to make this business card look more professional?”

METACOGNITION

OVERALL EXPECTATION

By the end of this course, students will:

1. **Reflecting on Learning:** identify and comment on their own and others' strengths and areas for improvement in analysing and producing business and technological communications.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Reflecting on Learning

By the end of this course, students will:

Reflecting on Personal Strengths and Areas for Improvement

- 1.1 identify their strengths and areas for improvement in understanding, analysing, and producing business and technological communications (e.g., *complete a self-assessment checklist on their work at appropriate times during the course*)

Teacher prompts: "What strategies do you find most helpful for understanding challenging documents?" "What would you choose as an example of your best work? Why?" "What specific writing skills would you like to improve?" "What communication skills do you have that would be effective in areas such as reception, sales, planning meetings, writing, or management?"

Explaining Creative Choices

- 1.2 explain and justify the creative choices they have made to enhance the effectiveness of their business and technological communications (e.g., *explain their rationale for the layout of a web page they have produced*)

Teacher prompts: "What elements did you include to tailor your presentation to the specific interests of your target audience?" "Did the oral presentation techniques you used help hold the audience's attention? Would you use them again? Why, or why not?" "In your opinion, how do the graphics you have chosen enhance the look and effectiveness of your report?"

Commenting on the Work of Peers

- 1.3 comment constructively on the work of peers, identifying and praising effective aspects and noting possible areas for improvement (e.g., *explain how a peer's work meets specific criteria of good design and/or clear communication; share positive comments orally with partners or in a small group; ask questions to help pinpoint possible discrepancies or confusing wording in a peer-produced draft*)

Teacher prompts: "Be sure to comment first on what your partner has done well." "Did you think your partner's presentation could have been clearer? Why, or why not?"